

A Model Issue

Or a look at what goes on inside to present a sparkling front

The excitement never ends at Digit. There was another round of it in May, while we were preparing for the June anniversary issue. Being a special issue, the stories obviously had to be off the beaten path—topics that weren't covered before, comparison test of products that hadn't been tested earlier and so on. Then of course, since we wanted to create a unique package with five content-packed CDs, there was double the amount of research and planning to ensure that everything was smooth sailing. Even the cover had to be special, befitting our first birthday.

All kinds of ideas were tossed around to make the cover stand out. After several brainstorming sessions, heated discussions and cups of tea, we finally settled on a cover that would have a gold touch to it, in keeping with the celebratory mood.

But first things first. We had to start off by choosing a female model appropriate for the cover. And if you are thinking why female, well, here's the answer. The model is selected on the basis of the cover story. Depending on the product covered in the leading story, we make the decision as to whether we must go for a male or a female model—products that are sleek, funky and 'smooth' are generally accompanied by female models (cellular phones, MP3 players, digicams and so on), while traditional and powerful computing products (hard disks, processors, monitors, etc), are graced by men. Anyway, getting back to the earlier and moot point. As we were going with the gold touch, obviously the best skin tone would be a dusky brown and so the hunt for the model with the right dusky looks was launched. The folks in charge of selecting the model did a thorough job, examining the short listed candidates taking into consideration every possible photographic factor—the appropriate skin tone, the right kind of sophisticated looks for a cutting-edge technology product, the lightning that would be used, and so on.

While the designers and photographers pored over the portfolios to pick the right model, there were some parallel (and unofficial) judging panels that were doling out their decisions. Almost all Digsters managed to sneak out some time to go over the portfolio that our

Every element that went into the shoot was carefully and painstakingly examined and checked and then checked once again—the lighting, make-up, clothes and so on. When the photographs were processed, the next task was to do the necessary high jinks in Photoshop to adjust the look and feel of the



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

photographers had brought in. Several rounds and several criteria and an even larger number of vastly differing opinions were forthcoming. But choose a model we did. There were some other interesting incidents. One that distinctly stood out was a top model's sibling insisting that we carry a story written by him if we wanted his sister to pose for the cover. Well, well...

The actual model shoot was to be held at a venue that was about 45 minutes away from the office premises. This involved lugging some equipment (an easy task) and a few excited souls (the more difficult job) to the destination taking care that neither of the two encountered any damage. Ashwin, one of our ace designers, was more than thrilled to accompany Mexy and Jiten, our in-house photographers to the shoot.

scanned image, so that it matched the magazine's spirit and the contents that would go on the cover. An easy task for Ashwin, except that he had to contend with the 'expert' opinions of everyone who happened to pass by his desk. Everybody was curious and excited about the anniversary issue, even those not directly working on Digit, and there were more ideas and suggestions being offered. We finally had to shift Ashwin to a secluded spot where he could work in peace and volunteers from the team took it upon themselves to make sure that he wouldn't be disturbed.

The final output obviously saw hordes of Digsters gathering around our man's desktop, admiring...er...the model, um...Ashwin's handiwork. Oh well, we can't really make up our minds about that. ■